

Brass

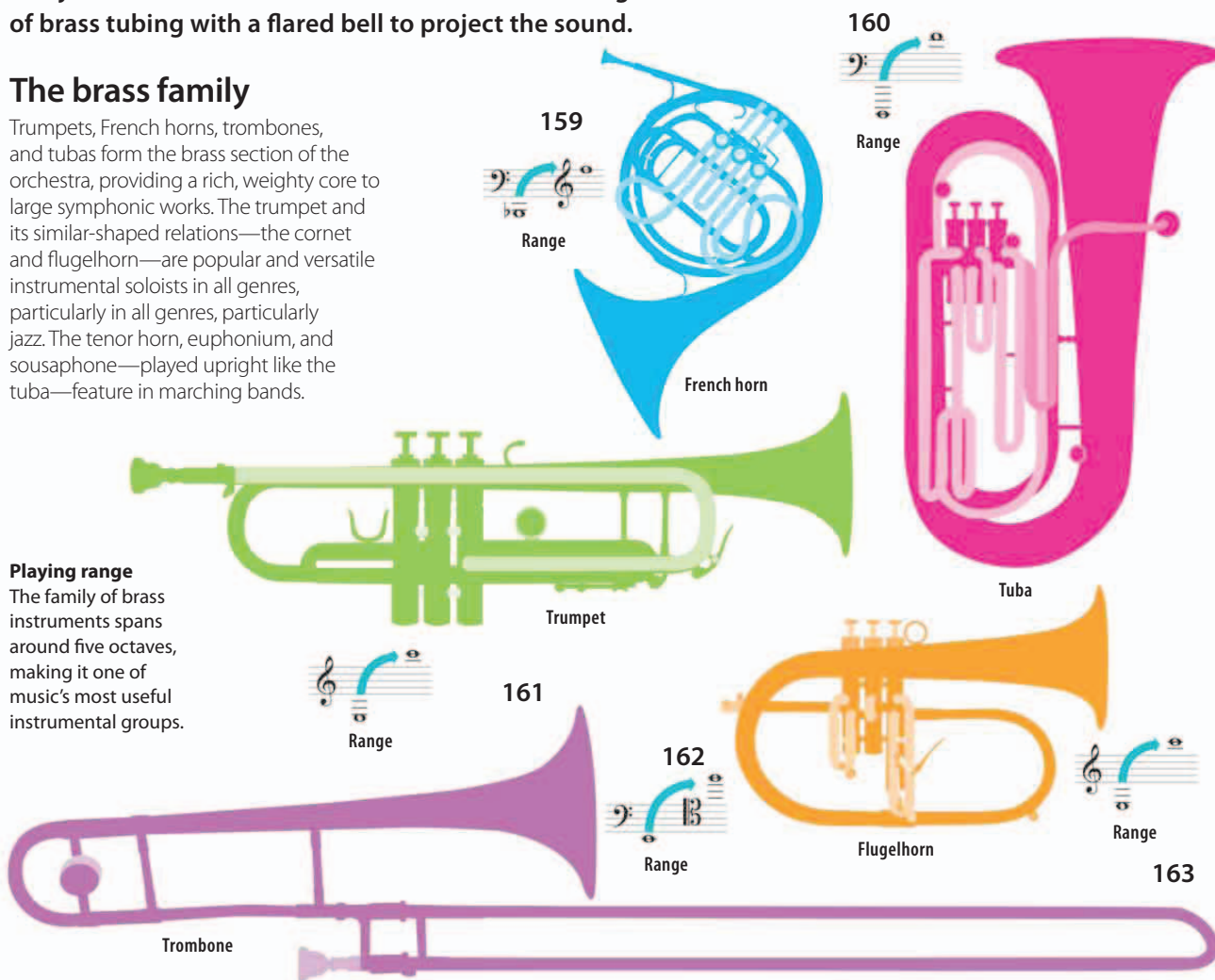
Brass instruments are some of music's oldest and most versatile instruments—at home, in orchestras, bands, and jazz ensembles. The instruments consist of a length of brass tubing with a flared bell to project the sound.

The brass family

Trumpets, French horns, trombones, and tubas form the brass section of the orchestra, providing a rich, weighty core to large symphonic works. The trumpet and its similar-shaped relations—the cornet and flugelhorn—are popular and versatile instrumental soloists in all genres, particularly in all genres, particularly jazz. The tenor horn, euphonium, and sousaphone—played upright like the tuba—feature in marching bands.

Playing range

The family of brass instruments spans around five octaves, making it one of music's most useful instrumental groups.



SEE ALSO

◀ 76–77 Transposition

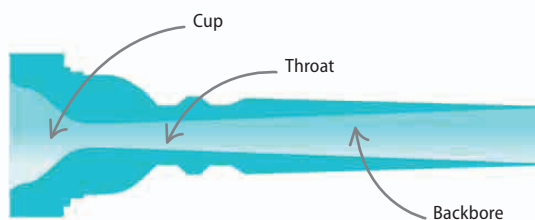
The orchestra 184–185 ▶

Ensembles 188–189 ▶

What is the score? 194–195 ▶

Brass mouthpieces

The sound of any brass instrument begins at the mouthpiece. The player's mouth is placed against the round metal rim of the mouthpiece – a technique called "embouchure". By "buzzing" the lips, air is forced into the tube of the instrument, causing it to vibrate and sound a note.



◁ Cup-shaped mouthpiece

All brass instruments have cup-shaped mouthpieces. The backbore is inserted at the top of the instrument. French horns use a small, deep cup, while trombonists prefer larger, flatter mouthpieces.